



EATEN

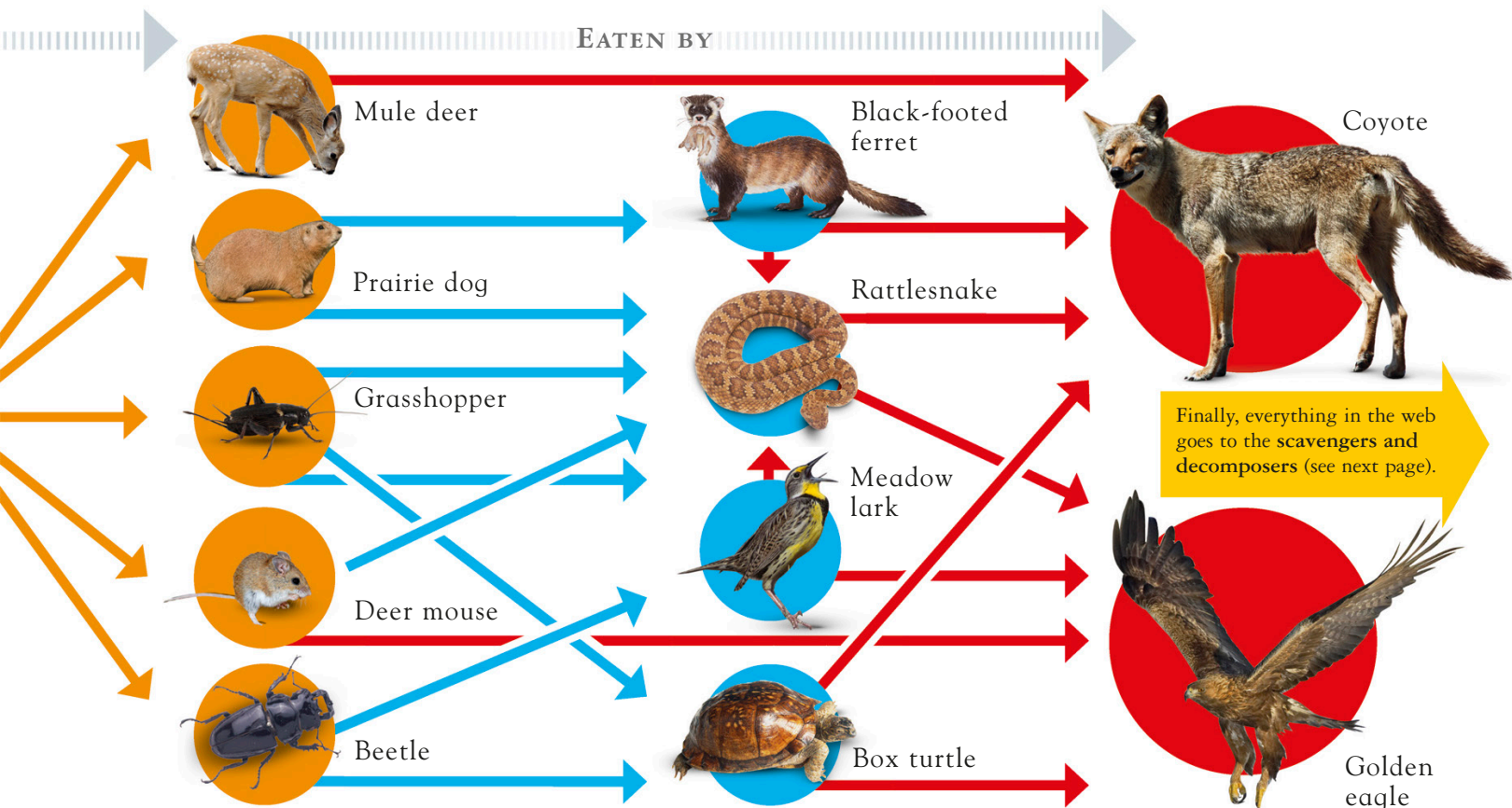
Most organisms can't make their own food so they have to get it by eating something that can. This is the start of a food chain.



There are rarely more than four or five links in each food chain. But most animals are part of several chains and eat more than one type of food to meet their energy needs. These interconnected food chains form a food web.

REGULATING THE CHAIN

Food chains have a way of balancing themselves out when the population of one of the links gets too large. Fewer mule deer could mean less food for the coyotes that eat them. However, if the coyotes starved and died, more mule deer would survive and reproduce.



Primary consumers are animals that eat plants—these are called herbivores. They help keep the vegetation at manageable levels.

Secondary consumers are animals that eat other animals—these are called carnivores. Most carnivores prey on herbivores or scavenge carcasses.

Tertiary consumers are at the top of the food chain. These are carnivores that eat other carnivores as well as herbivores.